

KF30 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

Mindfulness and meditation training teaches us how to step back from the clamor of our minds and emotions. We are then free to fully engage with the reality presented to us rather than compelled to impose our ideas of what we imagine life should or shouldn't be. By practicing mindfulness and meditation, we learn not to fear the present moment, ourselves, or others; instead, we observe reality with compassion and calm ourselves as we would calm a distressed child. We are developing skills that help us circumvent the traps and snares of the hunter, who, as we learned in KF lesson 12, tries to manipulate us with fears and cravings. With practice, our choices will become less influenced by the compelling need to feel safe, to restore our pride, to generate and flee self-hate, to have things go our way, and to save our Idol's life.

Calming Breath

1. Prepare

Sit up and stretch the crown of your head toward heaven, which will straighten your neck. Drop your chin a little. Allow your shoulders to fall back and relax. You may also wish to lie down. Settle into this experiment. Begin with a silent prayer for peace within yourself and in your life. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

2. Scan for tension

As you inhale, explore your body for tension. You might start with your feet and ankles, and on the exhale, try to release any tension you find. Continue to breathe deeply, and move your attention to other parts of the body. Remember to explore your face. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

3. Use sound

Sing the word *CALM* as you exhale. Use tone to vibrate your body and bring it into a state of rest. Here's an example of how that might sound. *(Give an example)* Feel your body soften and relax. Voice the long “ahm” sound for one breath and then rest for the next breath. As you practice, you may wish to scan your body again. Continue at your own pace for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

4. Use breath

When you feel ready, let go of singing the word out loud. Just whisper the word or allow it to flow in your mind with your breath. You might whisper the word *CALM* on one exhale and then rest for two deep breaths. As you continue to scan and release body tension, explore a rhythm that works for you. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Now, release the word altogether. Breathe deeply and occasionally sigh with a long exhaling breath. Continue to release any tension in your body and mind. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

5. Rest

Without strain or thought, rest in the stillness for one minute. If you find your mind wandering, use the word *CALM* to draw it back into stillness. To rest in stillness means to poise your mind in an attentive space without images, words, or thoughts. Breathe. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

Pause and gently stretch. Open your eyes and re-engage with the meeting. *(Pause)*

We are training our minds and bodies to relax on command. It is out of a calm inner peace that we find our path to orientation.

This is our teaching from James: “For the fruit of orientation is planted in peace by those who make peace.”¹

Our hymn for this lesson is *Spirit of God, Descend upon My Heart*.

Teach me to feel that Thou art always nigh.
Teach me the struggles of the soul to bear,
To check the rising doubt, the rebel sigh.
Teach me the patience of unanswered prayer.²

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?”)

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

KF Confession 7 describes the turning point toward healthy living:

We commit now to live in reality, choosing to believe rather than judge.

Let’s look again at what we have been learning.

1. Suffering is part of the rebirth and growth process

In the last lesson, we looked at the worksheet titled **Suffering: An Opportunity to See Yourself**. This worksheet is designed to help you see how you yourself generate much of your own suffering. Self-generated suffering is a colossal waste of your powerful energy, especially since this kind of suffering is simply the result of hurt pride. Once you can accept this, you can redirect that powerful energy toward actualizing your real growth and potential. Suffering is a vital part of the death, rebirth, and growth cycle. There is something about suffering that breaks the hard shell of our pride and releases

the life within. Meister Eckhart, the great medieval theologian and mystic, understood the value of suffering and said, “The fleetest beast that will carry you to perfection is suffering.”²

When you realize that suffering can be productive, you can choose to make friends with whatever suffering may be yours. When presented with a challenge, you can courageously accept that challenge, even though you know that you will suffer. You do that because you want more love, more skill, and more joy in your life. This is the path of glory. Let me give you a personal example. I often suffer from the stretching challenges of this ministry, but at the same time I recognize the value of that suffering. I see myself becoming the person I’ve always wanted to be, doing what I am designed to do, and I can now more effectively declare the glory of God in this world, which is my real business. My willingness to accept these challenges deepens, widens, and enriches my relationship with Jesus. With these wonderful rewards in mind, I choose to continue serving through this ministry. By making friends with my suffering and accepting the challenges that are necessary for my training, I offer my karis gift to God.

What challenges are standing before you? Could they be invitations to offer a karis gift to God? Is there an open door that you are afraid to walk through? Use your **Suffering Worksheet** to help you think it through.

2. You begin with yourself

As we learned in KF29, research has shown that through repeated action, learning, memory and, I would add, through orienting your energy, you can improve the quality of your life. You can also learn to recognize the positive potential of all your experiences, including experiences from your past.³ I know that this is true. I have seen people change their experience of a past event in just ten minutes. Most people imagine that they should be able to get the benefits of oriented change quickly and without much effort, but, inevitably, these illusions about instant, easy, and effortless progress invite discouragement. Cause and effect is always active. If people repeat untrustworthy actions, learn worthless information, remind themselves of their judgmental stories, and follow misoriented energetic patterns, they will continue to get stagnating and painful results. You are in KF to learn to do something new. You are developing the CORE muscles to make substantial and long-term changes, changes that are satisfying and do not disappoint. Every week, as we share our meeting preparation work, we celebrate areas of real strength that were not ours just a few weeks or months before. We stop focusing on our failures and learn to appreciate, today, all that we have gained.

3. Learn wisdom

It is a reality that we all live in a created material world, and each one of us is subject to the cycles of this material world. Every choice of action or inaction plants a seed that becomes a cause, and that cause produces an effect. So, when you make a choice of any kind, you set in motion a cycle of cause and effect. Some people can appear quite strong in certain areas of their lives because they have been trained to act, or naturally act, in ways that perpetuate productive outcomes. They habitually initiate cycles that produce productive change. You might envy these people, but they are often just acting out of patterns that support their Idol; the outcomes in other areas of their lives reflect continual strain, misorientation, and even remarkable foolishness.

In Karis Fellowships, you are learning to live the kind of life that frees you to make wise choices in every area. With wisdom from above, you can learn new patterns of thought and behavior that will support and perpetuate your progress.⁴ When present stresses urge you to return to old misoriented patterns of relieving tension, you can compassionately acknowledge your stress and yet make

different choices: you refuse to plant misoriented seed and choose to initiate productive cycles by planting quality seed; you take advantage of the early rains and endure with patience while you wait for the latter rains, knowing that different seeds require different amounts of patience to produce fruit;⁵ you protect and nurture what you have planted, and when you are aware of progress, rather than sabotaging it, you support and perpetuate your progress with clever skill.

4. Cycles are a reality

There is a time to work and a time to play. There is a time to act and a time to rest. There is a time to plant and a time to harvest.⁶ Does this sound familiar? The problem is that our pride does not want to recognize or submit to cycles. If we judge a particular timeline for our healing to be good, right, or fair, and one that we think we can control, we may become frustrated when we do not experience healing within that time frame. This prideful attachment to a certain timeline inevitably creates disappointment, but, with humility, we can learn to have confidence in the natural cycles. If the seed you have planted is good and trustworthy, according to the logos, you can anticipate just outcomes.⁷ If your outcomes are not productive, you can mindfully access your memory and trace the cause back to your past choices. By humbly acknowledging and learning from past experiences, you can effect positive transformation in your life.⁸ There is comfort in knowing you have that much power.

We may judge ourselves when we work or when we play, when we take control or when we let go. We can judge ourselves because we are not always successful or because we are too successful. Do you really think that judging yourself or others will further your progress? When we are oriented, we practice non-judgmental awareness in every area of life, including the cycles of our healing, and we do not attach to a particular timeline for achieving our expectations. Instead, we rejoice in the truth of what we are learning now. We re-parent and develop our souls today, and we set aside time for healthy rest, play, and laughter in the midst of all of our cycles. In whatever cycle we find ourselves, we can make oriented choices. Then, when we look back on our timeline, we will see goodness and mercy following us. We will have reaped a consistent harvest of abundant living.

5. Pride interferes with cycles

When you are resisting a cycle of life, whether one of training, rest, effort, or self-nurture, you might check out the **Suffering Worksheet**. The questions under PRIDE and THE MIRROR can help you recognize non-productive patterns. Are you pushing something because you judge a certain timeline to be best? Are you resisting something out of fear or laziness even though an opportunity is standing before you? You might share next week what bothers you about training or resting. Could pride or the fear of hurt pride be driving you to force, manipulate, and grab control, or to neglect, resist, and give up? Does pride prevent you from appreciating the effort and progress that you have made?

Our prayer might go something like this:

*Dear Creator, who understands the cycles of suffering, help me make the most of the cycles of my life.
(Repeat)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

Here is our confession:

We commit now to live in reality, choosing to believe rather than judge.

The Bible teaching for this lesson is a cornerstone concept of Karis Fellowships training. Our passage is from the Gospel of Mark, chapter 4, and follows the Parable of the Sower, in which Jesus compares our souls to soil.⁹ Good seed is planted, but the outcome of the seed is determined by the quality of the soil. Seeds fall on the road, on rocky soil, on soil full of weeds, or on cultivated soil, and each type of soil will produce a different outcome. If you want to know the quality of the soil of a person's soul, just throw some seed out there and see what happens. Jesus wants us to take responsibility for what our lives produce. He wants us to know how much power we have to shape our outcomes.

Now let's look at my translation of **Mark 4:28–29**.

²⁶And Jesus was saying, "In the same way the kingdom of God is like a man throwing seed onto the earth;²⁷ and he lies down to sleep at night and wakes up in the morning, and the seed sprouts and grows up in a way that he cannot see or understand.²⁸ The earth, acting out of its own volition, bears fruit—first the grass, then the ear, then the full grain in the ear.²⁹ And when the fruit yields up, immediately the farmer sends in the sickle because the harvest is at hand."

Take a deep breath

In this passage, Jesus is teaching about the cycles of cause and effect in the kingdom of God. Whenever you invest in the kingdom, you get more in return. You cannot always see or understand how this works, but you know that if you plant quality seed in the prepared soil of your life, you can expect quality results. God has created a power within all seed that, given the right environment, makes things happen. Your business is to provide an environment that will accommodate, protect, and nourish the seed of oriented choices that you plant. Just as farmers prepare soil to nurture the potential of natural seed, you can cultivate a life that nurtures the potential of your oriented seed. Once you have prepared that soil and planted your seed, you can rest while the soil and the seed together do this mysterious thing called *produce*. When the harvest is ripe, you can confidently, without hesitation, reap what you have sown. By cooperating with God's way of doing things, you become the cause of your own abundance.

Sowing and reaping is another way to describe the cycles of cause and effect that regulate the flow of resources in our karis relationship with God and with the Creation. This flow is the economic system of the kingdom of God and is kept circulating through mutual generosity and trust, not through contract, expectations, and law. In the karis economy of the kingdom of God, the cycles of cause and effect operate at two different levels. Level One is the foundation that we must lay before we can progress to Level Two, but our goal is to live at both levels concurrently. At the first level of the karis economy, the cause produces an effect that is fairly predictable, but at the second level, the effect cannot be predicted, so living at the second level requires a more developed quality of trust.

Let's take a closer look at these two levels.

Level One: Preparing the soil

We begin with the first level where the cause produces an effect that is fairly predictable. Here we ask

ourselves: *What outcome do I want?* We then make choices that will generate that outcome. At Level One of the karis economy, we learn to give the gift of just trying to do things God's way. Our effort is a gift to God, to our community, and to our True Self.

If you commit to living at this first level, you are choosing to do these three things:

1. **Obey kingdom law**—learn God's kingdom law of orientation and obey it.
2. **Cultivate more orientation**—learn what orientation feels like and looks like, and mindfully act in ways that cultivate it.
3. **Choose life**—avoid misoriented behavior.

When you practice these things, you become a cause that produces a predictable effect. You prepare the soil of your life for a harvest of peace rather than anxiety, and stability rather than chaos. This level lays the foundation upon which you build your karis life in the kingdom of God. At Level One, you begin to change the course of your outcomes. By regularly practicing orientation, you become increasingly aware of what misorientation feels like and less dependent on a checklist that signals misorientation. Your mindful sensitivity allows you to quickly get back into the flow and reconnect with God.

In Mark, chapter 4, we learn more about the economy of karis cause and effect that operates in the kingdom of God. Jesus teaches us to just sow good seed in prepared soil and see what happens. So, at this first level, we start sowing seed. For example, we choose to follow the Ten Commandments, and we learn to avoid the misoriented choices that Paul warns against in his letters. If your family or church has trained you to make oriented choices, be very thankful; it will be easier for you to begin this process. We can get into training at any age, however, and become the cause of a new and productive life. We can learn from the people around us who know how to live oriented lives. We can read, listen, and learn from books and other media. We can seek healing. We can learn to do what is healthy, what is good, and what produces oriented outcomes, no matter how we feel. In due time, and with God as our ally, we will see the direct effect of our oriented choices.

Level Two: Planting the seed

The second level of the karis economy of cause and effect also involves three choices, but because the results of these choices cannot be predicted, this level requires a greater depth of trustworthiness and faith. At this second level of karis, you have already developed confidence in the power of your oriented, trustworthy life. You prepared the soil in Level One, and now you actively and intentionally plant seeds by giving your true gifts—the gifts God designed you to give. Your gifts carry spiritual power that stimulates and expands your circulation with God and with the Creation. Although you cannot predict how God will respond to your gifts, you can trust that He will return to you only good and perfect gifts that will enrich your karis relationship with Him.¹⁰ You discover that His response is always immeasurably beyond all that you could ask for or imagine.¹¹

At Level Two, you show God that you are trustworthy by practicing the following three things:

1. **Love your neighbor as yourself**—treat very well those who support you.¹²

2. **Do good to the trustworthy community**—support members of the community who are investing in their true glory.
3. **Act with kindness toward the world**—offer gifts of care and support to those outside the community.¹³

The cause at this higher level of karis is your growing relationship with God. This is what makes this level so powerful. He invites, and you respond by offering the gift of becoming more trustworthy. Your trustworthy choices invite Him into more relationship, and He responds with more gifts and invitations. The effect or outcome of this mutual generosity is unpredictable, but it will always be exactly what satisfies and fulfills. Through experience, you learn to trust the Giver and can let go of attaching to a certain outcome.

I would now like to offer you my paraphrase of **First Corinthians 2:6–9**.

⁶We speak wisdom to those who are mature or living at the higher level of karis. This wisdom is not of this era, nor of the Idols of this era, which are passing away. ⁷We speak of God's wisdom in secret, as in an initiation to the secret society of the hidden things of the True Self. In the face of this era of Idols, God set this wisdom apart for our glory. ⁸This is a wisdom which none of the Idols of this era understand. For, if they had understood this wisdom which leads to our glory, they would not have crucified the Lord of Glory. ⁹Just as it has been written, "Eye has not seen, nor ear heard, nor has it entered into the human heart the things that God has prepared for those who love Him."

Paul is writing to the Corinthians about the karis economy. The Corinthians lived in the center of Roman commerce and its market economy. They only understood the pride system of the "era of Idols"—a system governed by expectations, contracts, and law. In this passage, Paul is showing the Corinthians that God works through a different system. God's kingdom circulates resources through the karis economy, and the outcome is beyond our imagination.

We saw in our passage from Mark that the farmer does his part by giving something away. That is a difficult concept for those who live in the market economy. The karis cycle does not begin by magic or by chance. The farmer does something. He faithfully throws his seed, and then he waits. He does not see or understand how the seed grows. That's what the second level of karis is like. We do oriented things, make oriented choices, and give without calculation or expectation. Marvelous things begin to happen, but we do not know how they happen. We cannot make direct correlations, nor can we predict how long it will take to see the fruit. This is why karis requires trust—not trust in a certain predicted outcome, but trust in the Person of God.

On this second level of karis, we begin planting seeds by learning to treat very well those who treat us well. We may feel tension about this because we have been taught that God greatly prefers that we give to people who appear to be in need. When we study the story of the Good Samaritan, you will see that loving our neighbor is equal to fulfilling the greatest commandment, which is to love God with our entire being. You will also learn that your neighbor is the one who rescues and helps you, the one who pulls you out of the ditch.¹⁴ Neighbors are those who are doing God's work in your life and, most likely, in the life of the community as well. By first loving and supporting your neighbors, you build a self-sustaining and trusting karis fellowship with a few other people. With this stable support system firmly in place, you can afford to extend support to the wider community.

Once our karis neighborhood is built up, we can extend goodness to the general community of those who are investing in their True Self. With gifts of support, we present ourselves to them as their neighbor and invite them into karis relationship. Our support lets them know that their effort is appreciated. They find that they are not alone in their struggle toward an authentic life.

Our last priority area for sowing oriented seed is the world. When we give our gifts to those who don't know God, we declare to them the glory and character of a generous God. We demonstrate His love and His willingness to help them. We plant seeds in their lives, but how that seed grows is not our business. We may see a response from the world, or we may not. However, we can be sure that God will respond to us according to His beneficent character, and we will see the karis cycle of generosity with God completed in our own lives. We will bring in our harvest with joy. One of the reasons for filling out your **Meeting Preparation Guide** is to keep a record of what you are harvesting.

Let's read my paraphrase of Ephesians 3:19–20. These verses express the generosity of God's character.

My prayer is that you may be filled with all the fullness of God who has the can-do power to accomplish everything exceedingly abundantly—far beyond all that we can ask or even imagine according to the activity of that power in us.

God gives His lavish gifts according to the measure of our karis activity; otherwise, we would be overwhelmed.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Creator and God, teach me how to plant that I might reap with joy. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

You might sip some clean water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider trusting God to do above and beyond all that you can ask for, imagine, or control. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you consider trusting God to do above and beyond all that you can imagine or control, breathe and recognize your feelings or lack of feelings. (Pause) You can learn to honor whatever you are feeling without allowing it to master you. (Pause) Recognize your experience with compassion, and breathe. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Awareness without judgment

Graciously allow whatever you are experiencing to rest in your awareness as you *consider trusting God to*

act on your behalf. Observe your experience without judgment. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Use this time to explore, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider trusting God to do above and beyond all that you can ask for or imagine.* Observe your sensations. How does your body react to your feelings? Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider the possibility of trusting God to do for you what is beyond all that you can imagine.* Do you feel comfortable, uncomfortable, or are you shutting down? Just observe. *(Pause)* What do you believe about God's efforts in your life? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Are you afraid of something? Observe your experience as just information. You might process with a long exhaling breath, or the Dragon Breath.¹⁵ *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome.* *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore God's efforts in your life.
- Welcome the Holy Spirit of truth and His creative power.
- Welcome your present reality and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.¹⁶

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I trust God's efforts in my life, I let go of the longing for power and control.
- As I trust God's efforts in my life, I let go of the longing for esteem and affection.
- As I trust God's efforts in my life, I let go of the longing for security and comfort.
- As I trust God's efforts in my life, I let go of the longing for perfection. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time of training and healing. Hold us in the power of the cycle of karis as You guide us to our glory and to the truth about Your good intentions for us.¹⁷ Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self and design, with our community and the rest of Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

Pray for KF members who work behind the scenes to make KF more efficient and accessible, and for those who give substantial financial gifts. Pray that God’s gifts to these people will be above and beyond all that they could ask for or imagine.

¹ James 3:18.

² <https://gutezitate.com/zitat/178274>.

³ Maggie Macnab, *Decoding Design: Understanding and Using Symbols in Visual Communication* (How Books, 2008), 174.

⁴ James 3:17. See KF28.

⁵ Joel 2:23.

⁶ Eccles: 3:1–8.

⁷ Rom. 2:6–11.

⁸ “Research has shown that repeated action, learning, and memory can actually change the nervous system physically, altering both synaptic strength and connections. Such changes may be brought about by cultivated change in emotion and action; they will, in turn, change subsequent experience.” See KF28.

⁹ Matt. 13:1–23; Mark 4:1–20; Luke 8:1–15.

¹⁰ James 1:17.

¹¹ Ephesians 3:20.

¹² Luke 10:27.

¹³ Galatians 6:10.

¹⁴ Luke 10:36–37.

¹⁵ See KF12.

¹⁶ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.

¹⁷ Jer. 29:11.